PART 8 OF 11 · LAYER 3: BEDROOMS FIRST

Bedrooms as clean zones

THE SIMPLE VERSION

We spend a lot of time in bed, so the bed matters most.
Zip covers go on the bed and pillows.
Sheets get washed every week.

Item	Recommendation
Mattress, box spring, pillows	Fully zippered allergen-barrier encasements on all three. Choose tightly woven fabric with a pore size under 10 microns; avoid nonwoven covers, which trap allergen and cannot be washed.[1] Studies show encasings reduce mite allergen exposure.[2]
Sheets, pillowcases, blankets	Wash weekly. Hot water is not required: warm or even cold washes remove most mites and allergen, and home water heaters should stay at or below 120°F to prevent scalding.[1] Dry on the hottest setting the fabric allows.
Comforters and duvets	Wash with bedding if possible. If not, encase them or run them through a hot dryer; comforters need about an hour in the dryer to kill all mites.[1]
Blankets that cannot be washed often	A hot dryer cycle of at least 10 minutes killed all mites seeded into blankets in testing.[1]
Pillows	Choose washable synthetic pillows over feather or wool, and encase them.[3]
Stuffed animals	Keep to a few favorites. Choose washable ones and wash weekly, or store them in closed bins.
Bunk beds	The sensitive child should sleep on the top bunk, with both mattresses encased.[1]
Window coverings	Replace heavy fabric drapes with wipeable blinds or roller shades. If curtains stay, use washable fabric and wash seasonally.[4]
Clutter	Remove knickknacks, open shelving, and stacks of books or papers that collect dust; store items in closed containers.[4]
Pets	Keep pets out of the sensitive person's bedroom at all times.[5]
Bed placement	Leave space around the bed to clean and inspect the nearby walls and floor.

Furniture and furnishings

THE SIMPLE VERSION

Smooth things are easy to wipe clean.
Fuzzy things hold onto dust, so we vacuum them a lot.

The best furniture for a sensitive household has a smooth, wipeable surface and nothing inside that traps dust or holds moisture. Health guidance recommends wood, plastic, leather, or vinyl furniture and avoiding fabric-covered furniture, wall-to-wall carpet, and heavy drapes.[6] If replacing something is not realistic, use the right column.

Item	Best choice	If you can't change it
Sofas and chairs	Leather, faux leather, vinyl, wood, or metal, with removable washable cushion covers.	HEPA-vacuum upholstery weekly, including seams and under cushions. Consider zippered dust-proof covers.[5]
Flooring	Tile, sealed wood, laminate, or vinyl, especially in the bedroom.[7]	Low-pile carpet, HEPA-vacuumed at least weekly, twice weekly in bedrooms.[1] If you steam or hot-water extract, make sure the carpet dries fully the same day.
Rugs	Small washable area rugs instead of large fixed rugs.[6]	Vacuum both sides; shake or wash outdoors when possible.
Headboard and bed frame	Wood, metal, or other wipeable surfaces.	HEPA-vacuum upholstered headboards weekly; avoid tufted fabric in new purchases.

Shopping guide: what the labels should say

Product	Look for	Skip
Mattress and pillow covers	Zippered, tightly woven fabric with a pore size under 10 microns.[1]	Nonwoven covers that cannot be washed.[1]
Portable air cleaner	True HEPA and a CADR that matches the room size (see Part 7).[8,9]	Ozone generators and ionizers.[1,10]
HVAC filter	MERV 13, or the highest your system can handle, in the exact slot size.[9]	Loose or bent filters that leave gaps.
Vacuum	HEPA filtration, or a central vacuum that vents outside.[1]	Unsealed bagless units that leak dust.
Hygrometer	Digital display with humidity, temperature, and ideally dew point. Check it with the salt test.[11]	Relying only on the thermostat reading.
Dehumidifier	Built-in humidistat and a hose connection so it can drain on its own.	Humidifiers or vaporizers in a mite-sensitive home.[12]

Your next step

Start with the sensitive person's bedroom: covers on the mattress and pillows, weekly hot washing, and less clutter. Use the shopping guide when you buy products.

Sources for this part

1. AAAAI/ACAAI Joint Task Force, Environmental Assessment and Exposure Control of Dust Mites: A Practice Parameter (2013). https://www.aaaai.org/Aaaai/media/Media-Library-PDFs/Allergist%20Resources/Statements%20and%20Practice%20Parameters/Dustmite-2013.pdf
2. Allergo Journal International, Avoidance Measures for Mite Allergy: An Update (2022). https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s40629-022-00242-5
3. Mayo Clinic, Dust Mite Allergy: Diagnosis and Treatment. https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/dust-mites/diagnosis-treatment/drc-20352178
4. AAAAI, Cleaning Tips for Allergy and Asthma Sufferers. https://www.aaaai.org/tools-for-the-public/conditions-library/allergies/cleaning-tips-for-allergy-and-asthma-sufferers
5. ACAAI, Dust Allergies. https://acaai.org/allergies/allergic-conditions/dust-allergies/
6. Alberta Health, Controlling Dust, Dust Mites, and Other Allergens in Your Home. https://myhealth.alberta.ca/Health/pages/conditions.aspx?hwid=rt1233
7. Cleveland Clinic, Dust Mite Allergy. https://my.clevelandclinic.org/health/diseases/17712-dust-mite-allergy
8. EPA, What Is a HEPA Filter. https://www.epa.gov/indoor-air-quality-iaq/what-hepa-filter
9. EPA, Guide to Air Cleaners in the Home. https://www.epa.gov/indoor-air-quality-iaq/guide-air-cleaners-home
10. EPA, Ozone Generators That Are Sold as Air Cleaners. https://www.epa.gov/indoor-air-quality-iaq/ozone-generators-are-sold-air-cleaners
11. Canada Mortgage and Housing Corp., Measuring Humidity in Your Home. https://publications.gc.ca/collections/collection_2011/schl-cmhc/nh18-24/NH18-24-1-2009-eng.pdf
12. ACAAI, Air Filters. https://acaai.org/allergies/management-treatment/living-with-allergies/air-filters/